BENGALI COLLECTION

NO. 04



WEST BENGAL ORIGIN

Dhokar Dalna

❀

Steamed Lentil Cakes in Spiced Gravy

Bengali Vegetarian Ingenuity at Its Best

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Dhokar Dalna

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Dhokar Dalna

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DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Protein Reinvented for a Vegetarian Kitchen

Dhokar dalna belongs to a specific and fascinating tradition within Bengali cooking, sometimes called "thakurbarir ranna" — literally, the cooking of the temple or big house — a repertoire of dishes historically developed for Bengali households and communities that avoided onion, garlic, and meat, often including widows observing strict dietary customs. Within these constraints, Bengali cooks developed remarkable ingenuity, and dhoka — steamed and pan-fried cakes made from ground chana dal — is one of their most inventive results.

The technique itself is elegant: chana dal is ground, seasoned, and shaped into a firm block, steamed until set, then cut into diamonds and lightly fried before being simmered in a tomato-based gravy. The resulting dish delivers real textural interest and substantial protein, standing in for meat or paneer in households where those weren't an option, without ever feeling like a compromise.

Dhokar dalna has since moved well beyond its ritual origins to become a broadly loved dish across Bengali households regardless of dietary custom, valued simply for how satisfying and craveable it is — proof that constraints in a kitchen, historically, often produced some of its most creative and enduring dishes.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Protein Reinvented for a Vegetarian Kitchen, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Part of the "thakurbarir ranna" tradition — dishes developed for Bengali households observing strict vegetarian customs, historically including some widows following traditional dietary restrictions. A showcase of Bengali culinary ingenuity, using humble lentils to create a dish with genuine textural and protein substance. Now enjoyed broadly across Bengali households regardless of dietary background, valued simply for its distinctive flavor and texture. A dish that exemplifies how cultural and religious constraints have historically shaped inventive, enduring recipes.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

30m	45m	4	Med
ACTIVE PREP	COOK + SET TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Blender, for grinding the dal
- Steamer or a wide pan with a lid for steaming
- A flat tray or plate, greased, for setting the dhoka
- Kadai or wide pan, for frying and the gravy
- Sharp knife, for cutting the dhoka into diamonds

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Dhokar dalna keeps refrigerated for up to 3 days. The gravy reheats well; if you have leftover uncooked dhoka pieces, they can be fried and added fresh to reheated gravy for the best texture, as the fried cakes can soften considerably after prolonged storage in the sauce.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the dhoka (lentil cakes)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Chana dal (split Bengal gram)	1 cup	200 g	1 katori
Ginger, grated	1 tsp	5 g	1 chammach
Green chili, minced	1–2	1–2	1–2
Cumin powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Turmeric powder	¼ tsp	1 g	¼ chammach
Asafoetida (hing)	pinch	pinch	chutki bhar
Mustard oil	2 tbsp	30 ml	2 chammach
Salt	¾ tsp	4.5 g	to taste
Oil, for shallow-frying	as needed	as needed	as needed

For the gravy (dalna)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Mustard oil	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Cumin seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Bay leaf	1	1	1
Dried red chili	1	1	1
Tomatoes, pureed	2 medium	200 g	2 medium

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

For the gravy (dalna) (cont.)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Ginger paste	1 tbsp	15 g	1 chammach
Cumin powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Coriander powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Red chili powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Garam masala	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Sugar	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Water	1½ cups	360 ml	1½ katori
Salt	to taste	to taste	to taste

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Chana dal is the essential base for the dhoka and doesn't have a good substitute for this specific dish — it's widely available at Indian grocers. This recipe is naturally onion-and-garlic-free, following the traditional niramish (vegetarian, without alliums) style — if you prefer, a small amount of asafoetida gives a savory depth often used specifically as an onion-garlic substitute in Bengali vegetarian cooking. Mustard oil is important for authentic flavor in both the dhoka and the gravy.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Making the Dhoka (Lentil Cakes)

01 SOAK AND GRIND THE DAL

Soak the chana dal for 3–4 hours, then drain and grind to a thick, coarse paste with minimal added water — it should be thick enough to hold its shape, not runny.

02 SEASON THE BATTER

Mix the ground dal with ginger, green chili, cumin powder, turmeric, asafoetida, mustard oil, and salt.

03 STEAM UNTIL SET

Spread the batter evenly, about ¾ inch / 2 cm thick, onto a greased tray or plate. Steam for 15–20 minutes, until firm and set completely through.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Making the Dhoka (Lentil Cakes), continued



Chef tip. test doneness by inserting a knife into the center — it should come out clean, with no wet batter clinging to it.

04 COOL AND CUT INTO DIAMONDS

Let the steamed dal cool completely — this is essential for clean cutting. Once fully cool, cut into diamond or square shapes.

05 SHALLOW-FRY UNTIL GOLDEN

Heat oil in a kadai and shallow-fry the dhoka pieces until golden brown on all sides. Remove and set aside.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Making the Dhoka (Lentil Cakes), continued

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The dhoka must cool completely before cutting — attempting to cut it while warm will cause it to crumble rather than hold clean diamond shapes.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Gravy

06 TEMPER THE WHOLE SPICES

Heat mustard oil in a kadai and temper the cumin seeds, bay leaf, and dried red chili until fragrant, about 30 seconds.

07 ADD TOMATO AND SPICES

Add the tomato puree, ginger paste, cumin powder, coriander powder, turmeric, and chili powder. Simmer for 8–10 minutes, until the mixture thickens and the oil separates at the edges.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Gravy, continued

08 ADD WATER AND SIMMER

Pour in the water, sugar, and salt, and simmer for 10 minutes to let the gravy come together into a cohesive, flowing sauce.

09 ADD THE FRIED DHOKA

Gently add the fried dhoka pieces to the simmering gravy and cook for a final 5 minutes, allowing them to absorb some of the sauce while still holding their shape. Finish with a sprinkle of garam masala.

Texture indicator. the dhoka pieces should soften slightly at the edges while still holding their form — they shouldn't disintegrate into the gravy.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Adding the dhoka to the gravy too early, or simmering it too long once added, can cause the pieces to fall apart. Add them toward the end and simmer only briefly.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot with steamed rice, a staple of Bengali vegetarian and festive meals alike.
- Often part of a niramish (onion-garlic-free) menu for religious occasions or observant households.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a bowl with visible golden dhoka pieces in a glossy red gravy, garnished with fresh coriander.

Family Style

- A hearty vegetarian centerpiece dish alongside rice and a simple green vegetable.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Texture Right

- Letting the steamed dal cool completely before cutting is non-negotiable for clean, intact pieces.
- Frying the dhoka until genuinely golden brown, not just pale, gives it enough structural integrity to hold up in the simmering gravy.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- The dhoka can be steamed, cooled, cut, and fried a day ahead, then simply added to fresh gravy when ready to serve.
- The gravy itself can also be made ahead and reheated, with fried dhoka added fresh for the best texture.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some cooks add a small amount of raisins or a pinch of sugar to the gravy for subtle sweetness, echoing the sweet-savory balance found in other Bengali dishes like cholar dal.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

260 kcal	11 g	28 g	12 g	7 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Gluten, Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Niramish Dhokar Dalna	the strictly onion-garlic-free version featured here, following traditional temple-style cooking.
Dhoka's Dalna with Potato	some households add small cubes of potato to the gravy for extra heartiness.
Dry Dhoka	the fried lentil cakes served on their own as a snack, without the gravy.

Why did my dhoka fall apart when I cut it?

Almost always cutting before it had fully cooled. Let it cool completely, even refrigerate briefly, before attempting to cut clean pieces.

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Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Can I bake the dhoka instead of steaming?

Steaming is the traditional and most reliable method for the right texture; baking tends to dry it out more than this dish calls for.

Is this dish very heavy?

It's fairly substantial thanks to the lentil protein, making it a satisfying vegetarian main rather than a light side dish.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Dhoka	steamed and fried lentil cakes, the centerpiece of this dish.
Dalna	a style of Bengali curry or gravy dish, often paired with a specific main ingredient.
Niramish	Bengali for vegetarian, specifically meaning without onion and garlic in this context.
Thakurbarir Ranna	literally "cooking of the big house," referring to a tradition of restrained, ritual-appropriate Bengali dishes.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Dhokar Dalna

30m	45m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK + SET TIME
4	**Med**
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

DHOKA (LENTIL CAKES)

Chana dal	200 g
Ginger	5 g
Green chili	1–2
Cumin powder	1.5 g
Turmeric powder	1 g
Asafoetida	pinch
Mustard oil	30 ml
Salt	4.5 g
Oil	as needed

GRAVY (DALNA)

Mustard oil	45 ml
Cumin seeds	4 g
Bay leaf	1
Dried red chili	1
Tomatoes	200 g
Ginger paste	15 g
Cumin powder	3 g
Coriander powder	3 g
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Red chili powder	1.5 g
Garam masala	1.5 g
Sugar	4 g
Water	360 ml
Salt	to taste

METHOD

01 **Soak and grind the dal.** Soak the chana dal for 3–4 hours, then drain and grind to a thick, coarse paste with minimal added water — it should be thick enough to hold its shape, not runny.

02 **Season the batter.** Mix the ground dal with ginger, green chili, cumin powder, turmeric, asafoetida, mustard oil, and salt.

03 **Steam until set.** Spread the batter evenly, about ¾ inch / 2 cm thick, onto a greased tray or plate.

04 **Cool and cut into diamonds.** Let the steamed dal cool completely — this is essential for clean cutting.

05 **Shallow-fry until golden.** Heat oil in a kadai and shallow-fry the dhoka pieces until golden brown on all sides.

06 **Temper the whole spices.** Heat mustard oil in a kadai and temper the cumin seeds, bay leaf, and dried red chili until fragrant, about 30 seconds.

07 **Add tomato and spices.** Add the tomato puree, ginger paste, cumin powder, coriander powder, turmeric, and chili powder.

08 **Add water and simmer.** Pour in the water, sugar, and salt, and simmer for 10 minutes to let the gravy come together into a cohesive, flowing sauce.

09 **Add the fried dhoka.** Gently add the fried dhoka pieces to the simmering gravy and cook for a final 5 minutes, allowing them to absorb some of the sauce while still holding their shape.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Chana dal	200 g	☐ Ginger	5 g
☐ Green chili	1–2	☐ Cumin powder	see recipe
☐ Turmeric powder	see recipe	☐ Asafoetida	pinch
☐ Mustard oil	see recipe	☐ Salt	see recipe
☐ Oil	as needed	☐ Cumin seeds	4 g
☐ Bay leaf	1	☐ Dried red chili	1
☐ Tomatoes	200 g	☐ Ginger paste	15 g
☐ Coriander powder	3 g	☐ Red chili powder	1.5 g
☐ Garam masala	1.5 g	☐ Sugar	4 g

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